

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 5 2

♥ A 7 2

♦ 7 4

♣ J 10 6 4 3

♠ A J 3

♥ 10 8 6 4

♦ Q 9 6 5

♣ 8 7



♠ Q 10 7

♥ K 9 5

♦ J 10 8 3

♣ K Q 2

♠ K 8 6 4

♥ Q J 3

♦ A K 2

♣ A 9 5

West

North

East

South

All Pass

1NT by South

Lead: ♣4

Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 3 : ♣ 1 : Total = 6

1NT

North's 1NT opening shows a maximum of 17 points. Add your 7 and you come up with only 24 - not enough to think about game. So you pass.

North would play 1NT.

Click

South plays 1NT. West leads the ♣4. East plays the ♣Q, then the ♣K, West playing the ♣3 on the second trick. East then plays the ♣2 which you win with your ♣A.

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You only need one more winner and there are possibilities in ♠s, ♥s and ♦s. But you need to be very careful. If you watched those ♣ spots you will realize that West started with 5 ♣s (he led the ♣4, later played the ♣3). So the defenders will win 2 more ♣ tricks to go with the 2 they already have. And they can also take the ♥A and ♥K whenever they want. In other words, they also have 6 winners. So the battle is for the 7th trick for either side. If you do anything that gives them a trick they will win.

So you don't try for a trick in ♠s or ♦s. Instead you play on ♥s, the suit where they have the 2 sure winners anyway. They will win one of their high honors, take their 2 ♣s, then play either ♠s or ♦s. You win and drive out the other ♥ honor.

If you try to get a winner by taking the ♠ finesse you will give **THEM** a winner and you will go down.

If you play your three high ♦s you will set up a winner for **THEM** and you will go down.

Only if you establish your ♥s can you set up a winner for **YOU** without giving them an extra trick.

Board 2

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 7
♥ A J 6 4
♦ Q 10
♣ Q J 10 5 2

♠ 8 6

♥ 9 3

♦ A 9 7 4 2

♣ A 7 6 3



♠ 10 4 3
♥ 10 8 5 2
♦ K J 8 6
♣ K 8

♠ A K Q J 5 2

♥ K Q 7

♦ 5 3

♣ 9 4

West	North	East	South
			1 ♠
Pass	1NT	Pass	3 ♠
Pass	4 ♠		
All Pass			

4 ♠ by South

Lead: ♣Q

last trump. Now take the ♦A and give up the lead. Ruff at the first opportunity and pull trumps, making 6 ♠ tricks, 2 minor suit Aces, one ♥ trick and a ♥ ruff in dummy.

It's easy to decide whether to draw trumps or not.

Always draw them - unless you have some other need for them first. Like in this hand.

Notice this. You cannot fault West for his opening lead, top of an honor sequence is very logical. **BUT**, if he had led a trump you would have gone down.

You have an easy choice, you open 1 ♠.

Partner responds 1NT.

Partner is showing 6-10 points. With 17 points you are strong enough to invite game. You show your 6-card suit by jumping to 3 ♠. Partner bids 4 ♠.

South plays 4 ♠. West leads the ♣Q.

South plays 4 ♠. West leads the ♣Q.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

You have no time to waste. You have no way to discard either minor suit loser, so you absolutely must ruff a ♥ in dummy. You dare not pull a trump. Win the ♣A in dummy and play a ♥ to your ♥Q. West will win and probably lead a trump. You win, cash the ♥K and ruff your small ♥ with dummy's

last trump. Now take the ♦A and give up the lead. Ruff at the first opportunity and pull trumps, making 6 ♠

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 7 3 2

♥ Q J 10 6 4 2

♦ A 7

♣ 10 5

♠ 10 6 4

♥ A 5

♦ 9 6 4 3

♣ K J 6 2



♠ J 5

♥ 9 7

♦ K Q 10 8

♣ A Q 9 8 3

♠ A K Q 9 8

♥ K 8 3

♦ J 5 2

♣ 7 4

West

North

East

South

Pass

2♠

All Pass

2♠ by South

Lead: ♥Q

One small worry - East's play of the ♥9 might be the start of a doubleton signal. If so, he may be able to over-ruff dummy. You should have played the ♥A on the first trick. Next you pull two rounds of trumps with ♠A, ♠K. Only then do you play ♥K and ♥8 ruffing with dummy's last trump. Fortunately East only had two trumps and cannot over-ruff, even though he is out of ♥s.

When you get back in you will pull trumps and lead toward dummy's ♣ K J, hoping to make a good guess.

As you see, the ♣ A Q were sitting badly and you could not win a ♣ trick.

The only way to make the contract was to ruff a ♥ in dummy.

You open 1♠. Partner responds 2♠. What is your bid?

This was easy. You had a minimum opening bid and partner gave a minimum response. You pass.

South plays 2♠. West leads the ♥Q.

South plays 2♠. West leads the ♥Q, East plays ♥9.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 3 : ♣ 2 : Total = 6

You have one loser too many. It doesn't seem you can do anything about the 3 ♦s but you might be able to avoid one of the ♣s if you are lucky. However, you can probably get rid of the ♥ loser by ruffing it in dummy.

Board 4

East Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 5 2

♥ J 9 8

♦ 6 4

♣ K Q J 10 4

♠ A Q 6

♥ K 7 5 2

♦ A 8 7 3

♣ 7 5



♠ J 9 8 4

♥ Q 10 3

♦ K 9 2

♣ 9 6 3

♠ K 7 3

♥ A 6 4

♦ Q J 10 5

♣ A 8 2

West

North

East

South

Pass

1♥

Pass

1♦

Pass

3NT

Pass

1NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♣K

The problem is that if you win the first or second ♣ and then try the ♦ finesse East may win and still have a ♣ to lead back to his partner. So you should hold up the ♣A until the third round of the suit. Then if East wins the ♦K he may not have another ♣.

Imagine that you had won either the first or second ♣. When East won the ♦K he would still have had a ♣ to return to West's hand. You would have lost 4 ♣ tricks and the ♦K.

But what if East **DID** have another ♣ when he won the ♦K?

Suppose you held up until the third ♣. When East won the ♦K here he had a fourth ♣ to return to West's hand. That means the ♣ suit split 4-4 so you would have lost only 3 ♣ tricks and the ♦K.

With 14 points you will naturally open the bidding. You should open a 4-card ♦ suit rather than a 3-card ♣ suit. Partner responds 1♥.

Partner might have bid a 4-card suit so you cannot support ♥s with only 3. Instead, you describe your balanced, minimum opener by bidding 1NT. Partner then bids 3NT and you pass.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♣K.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♣K.

Winners: ♠ 3 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 7

You need to find 2 more winners and they can come from the ♦ suit. You can finesse West for the ♦K. If he has it then you will get 3 extra tricks, but even if East has the ♦K you can still make 2 winners.

Board 5

South Deals

None Vul

♠ J 9 3

♥ A 5 3

♦ A K J 10 5 4

♣ 6

♠ Q 7 2

♥ K Q 8 6

♦ Q 9 2

♣ K Q 7



♠ 10

♥ 10 9 7 4 2

♦ 7 3

♣ 10 9 5 4 2

♠ A K 8 6 5 4

♥ J

♦ 8 6

♣ A J 8 3

West

North

East

South

2♦

3♦

Pass

1♠

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by South

Lead: ♦A

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♦A, then ♦K, then ♦J. East discards on the second ♦ and ruffs the third one with the ♠T.

Losers: ♠ 0? : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2? : ♣ 0 : Total = 3?

The loser count looks a little messy - that's because of the circumstances. If you could have just played three rounds of ♠s you would probably have had 0 losers, and if you ruff this ♦ you will have only 2 ♦ losers, but maybe create a ♠ loser.

But though the loser count is confused your plan should not be. You **DO NOT** over-ruff the ♠10. Instead you discard your one ♥ loser (a loser-on-loser play). East can have this trick but whatever he returns you will win, pull trumps in **THREE** rounds if necessary, and take the rest of the tricks.

Discarding the ♥ loser instead of over-ruffing was the winning Plan. If you had over-ruffed you would have lost the ♥, but you would also have to lose a trump. You made a good play.

But did you notice that West made a bad play? He should have cashed his ♥A before he led the third ♦ for his partner to ruff. Then when his partner ruffed with the ♠10 your goose would have been cooked.

You have an easy 1♠ opening bid.

But West overcalls 2♦ and partner bids 3♦.

You should be certain to have a partnership agreement on the meaning of a cue-bid after an overcall.

Most good players use it to show support for opener's suit and at least 11 points. In other words, a hand with which you would have made a limit-raise or better.

So you bid the ♠ game.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♦A, then ♦K, then ♦J. East discards on the second ♦ and ruffs the third one with the ♠10.